Writing for the Microsoft Feed

Making sure your fact checks have the impact they deserve

Microsoft Feed?

In early 2026, Lead Stories signed a contract with Microsoft to supply them with a machine-readable feed containing *all* fact checks we publish in English and all languages spoken in Europe. Microsoft can use this feed internally for various purposes (Trust & Safety, model training, disinformation trend monitoring, search engine improvements…) but they will not (re)publish the content anywhere.

They want to use this data to react quicker to ongoing misinformation trends, mainly focused on Europe and the U.S.

What this means for Lead Stories

- Our fact checks will have **more impact** and might eventually show up more in search results etc. in Microsoft products.
- An **extra revenue** stream directly from our published fact checks besides the (minimal) existing revenue from the ads on them.
- It is more important than ever to be fast, correct and compliant with all technical and form requirements. We are paid to **provide a working feed with correct information**. Let's provide one!
- We want to be useful so we should strive to be **timely on viral content**. No use getting a fact check in about a viral election campaign claim two weeks after the votes have been counted.

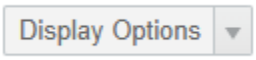
What is changing?

If you have been writing or editing following established procedures and rules, nothing much will change. **There will be two or three extra fields** in the "Edit Entry" screen that you need to **pay attention to and sometimes fill out**. That's it.

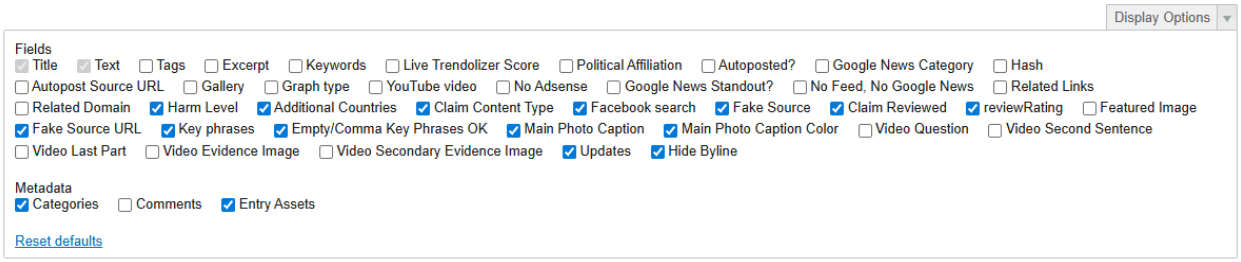
(A lot of this document is just a refresher on writing or editing following specific established procedures and rules because several features of the "Microsoft Feed" depend on it…)

What to do **first**

Log into Movable Type (via [the language] + leadstories.com/cgi-bin/mt.cgi) and open the “Edit Entry” screen for one of your old entries. In the top right corner there should be a “Display Options” button:



Click it open, you should see something like this:



Make sure all the boxes that are checked in the image above are also checked for you. The most important **new ones are “Harm Level”, “Claim Content Type” and “Additional Countries”**.

These boxes control which fields are visible for you under the text editor in the “Edit Entry” screen. After you make sure you enabled all the ones you need, click “Display Options” again to close this panel.

Tip: Note that all the fields under the editor all have corners that look like this:



You can click-and-hold on those corners to drag and drop the fields into any order that works best for your workflow because the order and display settings are tied to your individual user account.

What to do when writing/editing articles

Respect the three part structure of the first paragraph

All Lead Stories fact checks have an opening paragraph with following three parts:

- The claim as a **question**
- **"No, that's not true:"** or **"Yes, that's true:"** or in very, very rare cases something else that also **starts with a capital letter** and **ends in a colon**. After the colon follows a **sentence that starts with a capital letter (if it works for the language in question, lower case otherwise)** and which **summarizes the conclusion** of the fact check (*why* the claim is true or false).
- One or more additional sentences that further **summarize the evidence**.

Example:

> Is some number about the economy really 29% as the Prime Minister said in a viral online video? No, that's not true: The current number is closer to 5%, according to the latest official statistics. The 29% figure is what it was in 1962 but it has steadily decreased every year since then. The video was recorded during a 2026 event and there was no indication in the speech that the P.M. was talking about the past.

Reason: the text will automatically get split into parts (at the question mark, at the colon and at the first period after the colon) for various purposes (the Microsoft feed but also for automatically generating videos in some cases). If parts are missing or in the wrong place, things break down.

If the fact check gets turned into a video, the information in the headline and this paragraph is all most people will get to see. Many people who only skim your article will also only see this paragraph. So don't waste words there on explaining a general event or situation, stick to mentioning the conclusion and the evidence your article has for it ("An expert told Lead Stories…", "The official figures from the Ministry of …", "There were no recent news articles mentioning such an event…", "There was no such post on the person's official social media accounts…").

It is a summary, so you can skip giving people's full titles or exhaustively citing experts or sources. Do that **later in your fact check**. So **in the intro paragraph don't write**:

> "No, that's not true: Professor Smartypants from the University of Cleverness who holds the chair of the faculty of Being Right About Things on The Internet told Lead Stories the %29 figure was historically rooted in ancient forms of mathematical understanding during the Middle Ages and…"

But write:

> "No, that's not true: An expert told Lead Stories the %29 figure was something from history."

Put in a meaningful image caption

The diagonal “sticker” captions on the thumbnail images are sort of a Lead Stories calling card:



The text in this caption is supposed to summarize in 14 characters or less what the **reason** for the conclusion of our fact check is. It is **not supposed to be the conclusion** because that should already be in the headline (“Fact Check: AI Video Of Aliens Landing Is NOT Real”).

Why is it fake? What is the problem with the claim? How do we know this is not real? In the Microsoft feed, this field is called **“short verdict reason”**, and that is a very good description of what this is.

Examples: “1962 Figure”, “AI Video”, “Bad Math”, “Edited”, “Distorted”, “Satire”, “Not His Words”, “Misquote”, “Old Data”, “2004 Photo”, “Movie Scene”, “Fiction Story”, “Joke Post”...

Don’t make it “Fake”, “Hoax”, “Not Real”, “False” or something like that. **Those are conclusions, not reasons.**

It is free-form so you can get a little bit creative. But keep it professional.

All evidence links should be archived via archive.org (Wayback Machine)

Note: the blue underlined bits in this section of the document are not actual clickable links, they just illustrate where links are in the text.

Microsoft is asking us to provide a list of supporting links with each fact check. We can't just pull every link from the text of the article because sometimes we provide readers with background information that is not strictly needed to prove or disprove the claim or we might link to our own archives or older fact checks for more background.

For example, if we are fact checking a claim related to some current or historical event we might throw in a link to a news or encyclopedia article ("...after the recent protests in Iran." or "...during the U.S. Civil War when…" or "...you can see related Lead Stories fact checks here.") to provide some background info before diving into the claim itself. There is no need to add archive links for these since the fact check would still work without the information behind these links.

But **every link that is needed to prove or disprove the claim** should have **at least one archive link following it**, typically using a formulation like "...as this article (archived here) shows". We should always **include both the original link *and* the archive link** in the story. We want readers to click the original link where possible so we **don't deprive fellow publishers and journalists of traffic**.

The archive link needs to be there as well so we can **prove what the page looked like at the time of our fact check** and to provide a **backup if the original ever goes down**. Note it is **okay to provide multiple archive links for the same link** if one isn't working right or you are afraid some of the archives will stop working.

So this is okay: "... as the document (archived here) shows …"

But so is this: "... as you can see in the video (archived here, here and here), the …"

At least **one of the archive links** provided for each link **must be from the Wayback Machine** (i.e. archive.org), even if it is currently down or broken.

Reason: archive.org archive links contain the full original URL of the archived content so it is easy to pull the original URL from them to use it in the Microsoft feed.

Example:

> https://web.archive.org/web/20260219152150/**https://www.facebook.com/reel/1600671227782891**

Note: beware, we want the **actual archive.org archive link** (which contains **"/web/" followed by a bunch of numbers followed by the url being archived**). While in the process of

generating the archive you might also see a **"/save/" url** sometimes, that is **NOT the url we want** in the story as it is not actually a link to archived content:

> **https://web.archive.org/save/**https://www.c-span.org/program/white-house-event/president-trump-announces-federal-savings-accounts-for-children/669775

(Readers who click this link will just cause the Wayback Machine to try and archive this content *again*, which is not what we want.)

Other archiving services that are acceptable to use in emergencies (**in addition to providing an archive.org link**) are Perma.cc, Ghost Archive, Media Vault and Megalodon (Japanese UI but translate works).

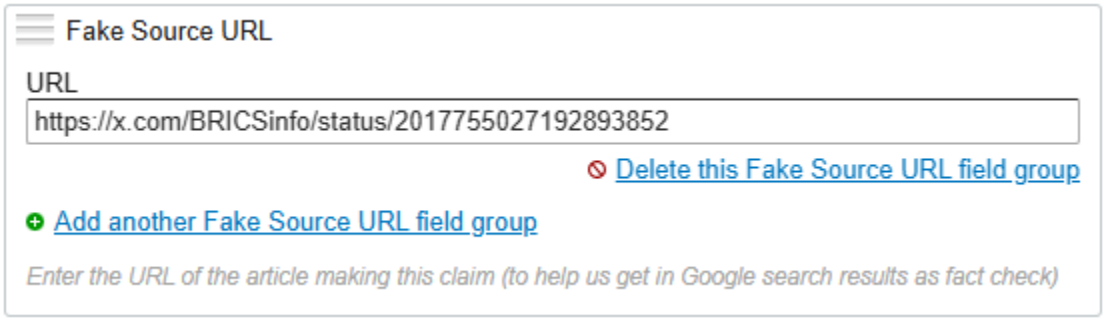
Each of these services has drawbacks (like not being able to archive certain platforms, limits on usage, not archiving the page layout/comments but just the media etc.) that make them inferior to using either:

- Direct archiving via web.archive.org
- Archiving static pages via the SingleFile plugin + conversion to WACZ and WACZ upload to archive.org with InVID
- Archiving video pages with WebRecorder and uploading the WACZ to archive.org with InVID.

If the upload fails or if the archive.org URL does not work right away, send your WACZ (or SingleFile HTML) to your editor so they can attempt to re-upload later.

We should **never use archive.is** (or any of the other subdomains of that service like .today, .ph, .vn…) because the owner is unknown, he is wanted by the FBI in a criminal investigation and he has been known to DDOS journalists.

Fake Source URL



Normally this is already automatically filled with a value that comes from fastcheck.cgi. It should be the link to where the claim was found. It needs to go to the exact post, video, article etc., not just the top level domain.

Make sure you get this right, don't just point it to a post or article generally talking about the subject your fact check is about. If our rating says "False" we are effectively telling search engines etc. not to trust the content at this link and we are putting our reputation as fact checkers behind that assessment. So don't treat this as an afterthought, this has real world impact!

Claim Content Type

This one is really simple. What type of content will people get if they follow the link to the content we are fact checking? Is it an image, a text, a video or a piece of audio?



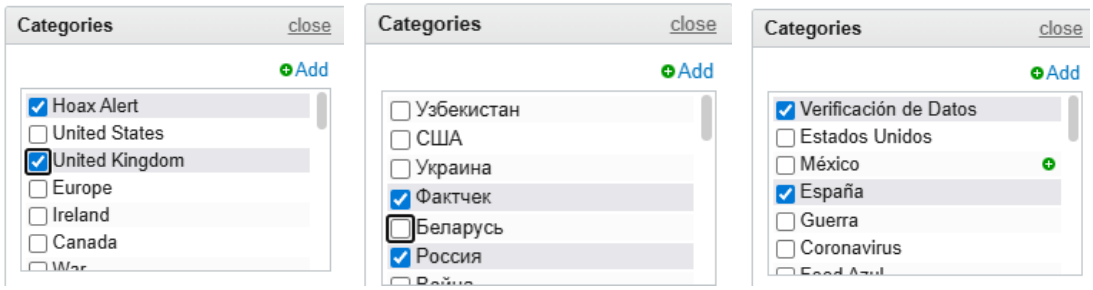
Note: it is about what is behind the link, not about where exactly in the content the claim is made. So if the claim is in the text overlay or the soundtrack of a video, the content type is still "video". If the content is a meme image where the claim is made in the text in the picture, the content type is still "image".

Country information

Each Lead Stories website publishes in one language and in most cases that language corresponds to one country. For fact checks **where the country corresponds to the language and where the topic of the fact check is only relevant to that country** there is **no need to do anything extra**.

For example a Hungarian story about a Hungarian politician doing something in Hungary or a Romanian story about an event that happened in Romania can be safely assumed to be relevant to Hungary and Romania, respectively, and this will automatically be reflected in the Microsoft feed.

However, for **some languages** (English, Spanish and Russian) there are **multiple countries/markets** the fact check can be relevant for. **On those sites there are country or region specific categories that must be selected for the fact check**, for example “United Kingdom”,“Russia” or “Spain”.



This will place the story in the appropriate category in the navigation bar or menu on that site:



It will also note in the Microsoft feed that the fact check is relevant to this market.

No matter if the fact check is on a site with a single country language or on a multi country language, **if the fact check mentions additional relevant countries or territories** they should be put in this box, **separated by commas, in English**:



Example: a Czech fact check about a meme that has a Czech celebrity talking to Chinese President Xi about rebuilding Gaza should have “China, Gaza” entered into this box (no need for “Czech Republic” since that is already covered by the default market/country of the site).

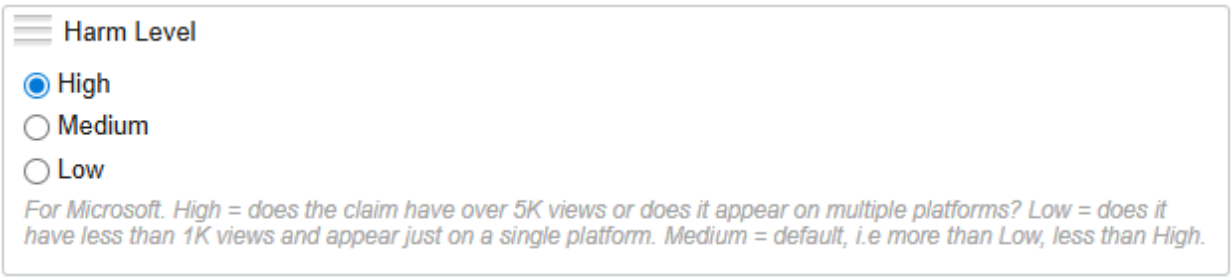
Harm Level

This one is a bit misnamed but it is the name used in the Microsoft feed so we are stuck with it. A **better name** would probably be **“reach”** or something like that. The levels were defined by Microsoft as follows:

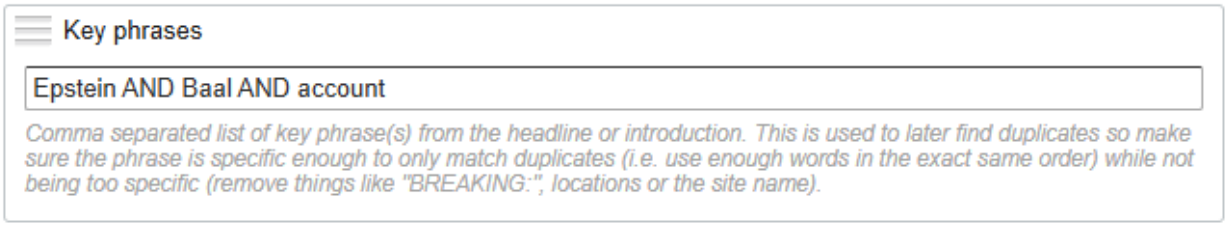
- Does the claim have more than 5000 estimated views or is it present on multiple platforms → HIGH
- Does the claim have less than a 1000 estimated views and is it present on just one platform → LOW
- Anything in between → MEDIUM

Generally at Lead Stories we don’t bother with sub 1000 view claims on a single platform unless we have good reason to believe the claim has the potential of going viral. With such claims, do a quick search on Google and one or two platforms to see if you can spot versions with more views or on more platforms that may have shown up since the story was selected for fact checking. Who knows, it might be a HIGH or MEDIUM by now…

Most stories we do will probably be in the HIGH category, as 5000 views is quite a low barrier.



Key Phrases



This one still trips many people up, so pay attention. This must be filled out with any of these three things:

- **An exact phrase** that can be used to **find copies of the claim** by looking for content that has that exact phrase in it (typically if something is a quote or a title of a specific viral video or article). If there is a comma in the phrase, put it in double quotes.
- **Several such exact phrases, separated by commas.** Each of these phrases, **independently, should be able to be used as a search term to find copies** of the claim that have **any** of the exact phrases in it. If a phrase has a comma in it, put it in double quotes.
- **Several keywords or phrases separated by "AND"** that can be used to find copies of the claim by looking for content that has **all** those keywords and phrases in it.

Things NOT to put in there:

- **A single word**. Unless it is *very* specific and will almost always match only relevant content (example: "frazzledrip" is the name of a supposed video in some conspiracy theories, almost nobody else will ever use that word.)
- **OR**: red rockets OR blue bananas → **the "OR" operator is not supported**.
- **Brackets**: (red, green) AND blue → This will look for the literal string "(red, green)"
- **Mixed "AND" and comma phrases**: this AND that, other thing, third thing → one type of notation only please

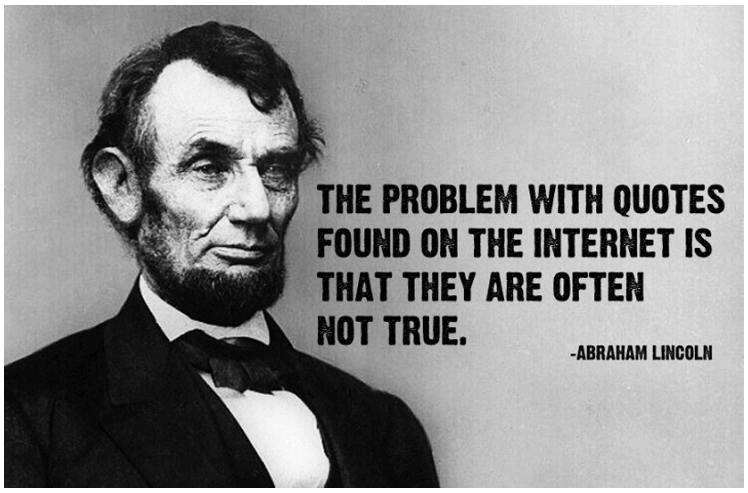
Good key phrases would allow someone to search for more content that exactly matches the claim, without:

- Excluding too many matches that would also be valid (false negatives)
- Including too many matches that are not valid (false positives)

Good examples:

- The problem with quotes found on the internet is that they are often not true → Matches every instance of the fake Abraham Lincoln quote
- "To be or not to be, that is the question" → Matches every copy of the quote, even though it has a comma in it

- vaccines cause autism, autism caused by vacines, autism is caused by vaccines, the cause of autism is vaccines → Matches any of these variations
- red AND blue AND bank account AND Epstein → Matches all stories about a red and a blue thing that mention Epstein and a bank account.
- Lincoln AND quotes AND internet AND true → will also find the variations where they left off Abe's first name while still not matching with too many false positives



Bad examples:

- The state of being or not being is the issue being questioned → This will not match Shakespeare's text
- quotes, internet, Abraham Lincoln → This will match *every* document on the internet that mentions "quotes", every document metioning "internet" and every document mentioning "Abraham Lincoln", which will return way too many results (and most of them will be unrelated to the claim)
- red AND blue AND "bank account" AND Epstein AND Chase Manhattan AND January AND raining AND email AND transfer AND million → This is far too specific and will exclude lots and lots of content that is also speaking about the red and blue thing in Epstein's bank account (if that is what the fact check is about)
- red, blue, white AND gold → this mixes styles. Either use comma separated phrases or "AND" separated phrases/words, not both.
- McDonald's OR Pizza Hut OR Burger King → this will look for the full phrase "McDonald's OR Pizza Hut OR Burger King". **The "OR" operator is not supported.** If you meant to search content with any of these restaurants, use a comma separated list.

Claim Reviewed



This should be a single, full sentence that clearly expresses the claim the fact check is investigating.

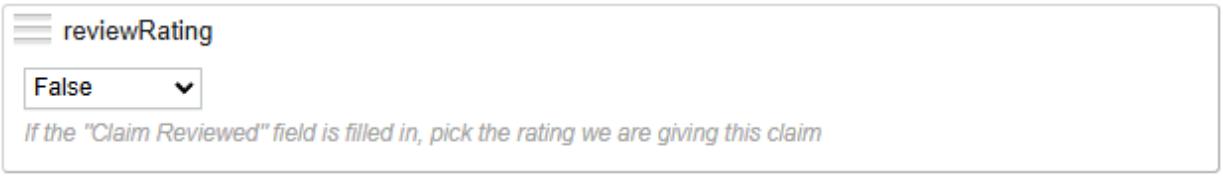
Be exact! The claim we are checking here is not that “Aliens are landing in Paris” or that the “Video shows aliens landing in Paris”.
→ We don’t know if any aliens are landing or not. (But we *do* know *this* video is made with AI.)
→ The video actually *does* show aliens landing in Paris. (They are just not real ones.)

Ask yourself things like:

- Are we checking if someone said something, or are we checking if the thing they said is true?
- Are we checking if a certain image is fake/edited/manipulated or are we checking if the thing depicted in the image is real/happened?
- Are we checking if a certain story originated as news (“no, it originated as satire…”) or are we checking if the story happened for real?
- Are we checking “this is definitely what happened” or are we checking “this particular version of events definitely didn’t happen”.

Ideally, the first sentence of the fact check should be this but formulated as a question: “Does a viral video show actual aliens landing in Paris?”

Review Rating



What does the conclusion of your fact check say about the claim, on a scale of:

- False
- Mostly False
- Unproven
- Mostly True
- True

Given the type of stories and claims Lead Stories usually handles, in 98% of cases this is going to be “False” with a very rare occasional “True” (or an “Unproven” if we are doing a “What we know” style story during a breaking news event).

(We tend not to do “Mostly” stories as those are often about wishy-washy, vague, opinionated, semantically loaded or rhetorical claims.)

What to do if you have questions or ideas for improvements

- Read this document very carefully, then read it again. It explains the specific reasons for many of the rules so before you start thinking about possible improvements or offering suggestions make sure you understand what goals we are trying to accomplish by doing things a certain way and check if your suggestion would still help us reach those goals.
- Email questions to maarten@leadstories.com and I will try to answer them in a new section of this document.
- If you want to score extra points, mention the word “banana” in your question or example to prove you read the document all the way through.
- If your question or idea does not contain that word I will start by assuming you didn’t read the document thoroughly.